MASTER OF BUSINESS ADMINISTRATION

SEMESTER 1



DMBA114

BUSINESS COMMUNICATION

Unit – 3

Guidelines for Written Business Communication

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1. INTRODUCTION

Writing skills are crucial and critical in business communication. Any inconsistency in writing the message might lead to misunderstanding or miscommunication. Grammatical errors, spelling, punctuation, and typing can affect business communication significantly. Therefore, maintaining clarity and concreteness of the messages is vital in business communication. You might lose your customer if you fail to communicate the information correctly and completely. At the same time, you must remember that general writing is different from business writing in terms of tone, language, and degree of formality of communication. Some of the dos and don'ts of business writing will be highlighted in this unit. This will lay the foundation for writing business letters and reports.

We cannot say that all business communications are positive. Some experts have noticed that technological advancements have made communication simpler and more efficient. This has gradually reduced the formal writing skills of business people. Marty Blalock, in his article 'Why Good Communication is Good Business' has pointed out that ineffective communication is expensive. According to the National Commission on Writing, American businesses spend about $3.1 billion a year to train their employees on writing.

Blalock has also pointed out that the Commission supports the requirement of effective business communication skills in employers.

About two-thirds of jobs in large American companies are based on writing duties. Many American companies have involved 'assessment of writing skills of job seekers' as part of their hiring process.

(Source: http://www.ehow.com/list_7440247_trends-business- communication-today.html#ixzz1dl0YlibM)

This unit helps you to answer the following questions:

1. What are the general principles of writing?
2. What are the stages of writing?

In this unit, we will learn how to improve written communication in general. We will also discuss some guidelines for effective business writing.

1.1. Objectives

After studying this unit, you should be able to:



- Evaluate your writing style
- Identify common errors in English usage
- Discuss the appropriate use of active and passive voice, grammar and punctuation
- Distinguish between general and business writing
- Compose a piece of business communication confidently

2. GENERAL PRINCIPLES OF WRITING

Written messages must be made as readable as possible. We must make them uncomplicated and easy so that even an average person can understand their meanings. Readability, in turn, is determined by the length of words, sentences, and paragraphs. A common mistake made by writers, especially Indian writers, is to try to impress the reader by using flowery language and an oratory style of writing. Two broad principles of writing are "Write to express, not to impress" and "Keep it short and sweet." A good writer is one who follows these principles and asks himself/herself even before framing a sentence "What am I trying to say? What words will express it?"

Let us try to understand these principles first by discussing the different stages of writing. We will then become familiar with some tips on writing style, followed by some specific rules regarding English language usage, spelling, and punctuation.

2.1. Writing Methodology

Writing methodology comprises of three stages:

- Prewriting
- Writing
- Reviewing

Figure 5.1 depicts the three stages of writing.

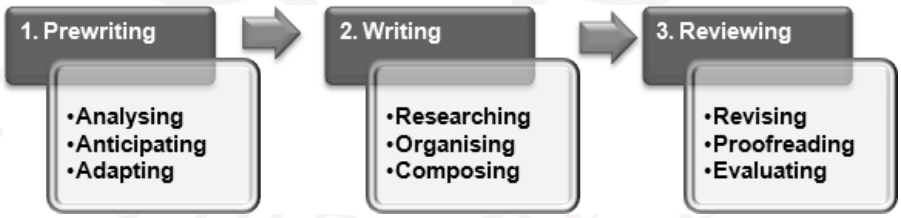


Fig. 5.1: Stages of Writing Methodology

(Source: Reproduced from Guffey, M. E., and Loewy, D. (2011). Business Communication: Process and Product, 7th ed. USA: South-Western Cengage Learning)

Let us now discuss them in brief.

Prewriting

Prewriting is a structured thinking process that helps you to explore and understand what to write. The techniques of prewriting help you to determine the approach to choose and plan to implement it. Usually, a prewriting plan enables you to explore a topic from different perspectives. It also helps you

to discover new and original ideas for writing the topic. In the pre-writing stage, you analyse your audience to determine your audience requirements, anticipate the audience's knowledge and design the strategy that can be adapted to communicate. For example, what language do you have to use to convey the message to the audience, formal or conversational?

Writing

After knowing the audience and developing strategies, you can research the topic and gather essential data. Once you gather the required data, you can organise your content i.e., decide the flow, group similar facts, identify the important facts to be mentioned, etc. Later, you begin to compose or write i.e., construct sentences and paragraphs. First, you write a draft. While drafting, you write the information that you have researched in your own words. You build sentences and paragraphs even though they are not 100 percent perfect. You read what you have written and check whether what you have written is what you mean. You then get the document reviewed by others and ask for suggestions to improve the content.

Reviewing

In this stage, you revise, proofread, and evaluate the message. You check whether the sentences are complete and if your content is correct. You check for spelling, capitalisation, punctuation, grammar, and parallelism. One must check whether the clarity of the written content is maintained and also ensure that no errors are present in the content. Figure 5.2 depicts the inverted pyramid of review steps.



Fig. 5.2: Review Steps

The four steps shown in figure 5.2 can help you to make your review process effective. The four steps can be explained as follows:

1. ***Review for strategy*** **–** Review whether the document adheres to the design strategy. For example, check whether objectives are accomplished, the main idea is conveyed first or last, the technicalities are defined as per target audience requirements, language style used is as per audience requirement, credibility is established, logical flow, etc.
2. ***Review for macro issues*** **–** One must review the whole document before reviewing sentence by sentence. For example, document design, the connection between sections and subsections, effectiveness of paragraphs or sections, etc.
3. ***Review for micro issues*** **–** Review the sentences and words, for example, check for wordiness, long sentences, complex and incomplete sentences, clarity of sentences, etc.
4. ***Review for correctness*** **–** Review for the correctness of the content with respect to grammar and punctuation, for example, parts of speech, parallelism, incorrect use of commas, etc.

SELF-ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS – 1

Fill in the blanks:	
1	_____ is a structured thinking process that helps you to explore and understand what you have to write.
True or False:	
2	You check for wordiness, long sentences, and complex and incomplete sentences when you review for macro issues. (True/False)

2.2. Tips in Writing Style

You can improve your writing style by choosing the right words for conveying the meaning. Some of the common problems include the use of complicated words, the use of jargon, slang, colourful language, and mistakes in using the parts of speech.

Simple vs. complex words

As far as possible, the sender should select words that are within the receiver's vocabulary. If the chosen words are too complex for the receiver, the latter may not get the correct meaning of the message by guessing the wrong meaning of the word. The receiver may also perceive that the sender intentionally selected a complicated word to show-off. Therefore, it is important to consider the educational level and the knowledge of the reader.

Hence, it is better to rely on plain, simple words, such as the ones shown in the first column, rather than in the second column of table 5.1, even though they mean the same thing.

Table 5.1: Some Simple Word Equivalents for Complex Words

Simple word equivalent	Complex word
About	Approximately
Do	Accomplish
Improve	Ameliorate
Show	Demonstrate
Change	Modify
Ask	Interrogate

This is because short and simple words convey ideas more effectively and require less time and space. They also invite the sender to concentrate on ideas, rather than calling attention to the words themselves.

Jargon, slang and metaphors

'Jargon' refers to technical terms that belong to a particular subject area or discipline. For example, medical jargon means using terms understood by only medical practitioners. Common people may not understand these terms. Some of the terms in the medical jargon are, 'agonal' meaning a major negative change in a patient's condition, FX for fracture, and IM for intramuscular. Such terms are to be avoided in general writing since they would be out of the comprehensibility of ordinary readers. In the case of highly technical reports, where a reader can understand the technical terms using jargon becomes necessary. For example, computer jargon such as browser, bus, cache, chip, cookie, CPU, crash, database, dot pitch, download, driver, and file can be used only while authoring reports related to computer technology.

'Slang' refers to casual words that are not accepted and recognised in a standard English dictionary. For example, 'ace' means very good, 'action' means excitement, 'blown away' means greatly impressed, 'flip out' means lose control and 'glitch' means defect. While they could be used in a limited way in general or informal writing, they are to be avoided in business writing, which needs to be formal in nature.

A 'metaphor' is a figure of speech and refers to colourful comparisons which evoke visual images. For example, consider the following sentences:

1. He is 'rock solid' in his support.
2. We provide an 'umbrella of insurance' product for your security.

Such phrases may be used in informal writing or advertising, but in the case of business communication which must be objective and formal, it is advisable to avoid them.

Parts of speech

In the same way that the use of big, complicated words may result in the receipt of the wrong message, the use of small words in the wrong way grammatically could have the same result. Such problems exist in all parts-of-speech categories. Some of the parts of speech which we will be discussing in this unit are:

- Nouns
- Pronouns
- Verbs
- Adjectives
- Adverbs

Let us now briefly discuss each of these parts of the speech.

Nouns

Just as the main actor in a film is the most important character, the subject in a sentence is the most important noun. There are two categories of nouns – 'abstract nouns' or nouns that cannot be visualised and 'concrete nouns or nouns that can be visualised. A message will be understood more clearly if concrete nouns are used as subjects in a sentence, rather than abstract nouns. For example, consider the following two sentences:

1. 'Cancellation' of the contract will be done in March. (Use of abstract noun as subject)
2. The 'contract' will be cancelled in March. (Use of concrete noun as subject)

In this example, the second sentence, using 'contract' as the subject, is likely to be understood more clearly by the receiver. Not only is 'contract' something that can be visualised, but it also emphasises the main idea in the sentence.

Let us consider another example.

That 'decision' can be made only by the supervisor. (Abstract noun as subject)

Only the 'supervisor' can make that decision. (Concrete noun as subject)

Pronouns

Sometimes, using the masculine form of a pronoun might be taken in an offensive way by the receiver, especially if the receiver happens to be a woman. Even if the receiver is not a woman, the use of a

masculine pronoun may convey the impression of being sexist. For example, consider the following sentence: "You need to consult your professor on that subject, but he has to be a specialist in the area of Finance". In this sentence, the use of the masculine pronoun 'he' conveys the unintentional message that professors can only be men and not women, which could be taken as an offence. Such offensive pronouns can be avoided in the following ways:

1. Avoid the usage of pronouns completely
   For example, "you need to consult your professor on that subject, but a specialist in the area of Finance is required."
2. Repeat the noun
   For example, "you need to consult your professor on that subject, but the professor has to be a specialist in the area of Finance."
3. Use a plural noun
   For example, "you need to consult some of your professors on that subject, but they have to be specialists in the area of Finance."
   (The use of 'they' avoids implying that professors can be only men).
4. Use pronouns from both genders
   For example, you need to consult your professor regarding that subject, but he or she has to be a specialist in the area of Finance.

Another principle regarding the use of pronouns is to avoid excessive use of the first-person pronoun 'I', since this gives the impression that one is always talking about oneself. Never sound too pleased with yourself or boast of your own achievements. This is especially true of business writing, where it is important to be objective, rather than subjective.

The second-person pronoun 'you' also needs to be used with care. A rule of thumb is to use the second person pronoun when emphasising a positive idea or message and to avoid the second person when presenting a negative idea.

The following two sentences illustrate the usage of second person pronoun:

1. 'You' made a good presentation.
2. 'You' made a number of mistakes in the report.

The first sentence contains a positive idea. Therefore, the second person pronoun should be used, since it gives credit to the person who made the presentation. But, the second sentence contains a

negative idea and emphasises that 'you' are responsible. This should be avoided by framing the sentence differently, such as "The report contained a number of mistakes."

Verbs

Since verbs are action words and action is an essential part of a sentence, the correct use of verbs is important. Senders of messages must use verbs that agree in number with the sentence's subjects.

The following sentences illustrate the misuse and the correct use of verbs in sentences:

1. Only one of the students 'are' present. (Wrong usage) Only one of the students 'is' present. (Right usage)
2. Each of the following reports 'have' been modified. (Wrong usage) Each of the following reports 'has' been modified. (Right usage)

Note that the singular form of the verb and not the plural should be used in both the above sentences, to agree with the subject, which is in singular form ('Only one' and 'Each').

Verbs must also agree in person. The most common errors are made in agreement with the third person and the second person. For example, the following two sentences illustrate the usage of verbs in agreement with person:

1. He 'doesn't' like to work late.
2. You 'were' informed that the exams begin next week.

Thirdly, since verbs indicate the time of action – past, present, or future, they should be used in the correct tenses. The tenses should also be used consistently.

The following sentences illustrate the misuse of tenses:

1. He 'listens' to the presentation and 'gave' his feedback.
2. The manager 'spoke' to the customer, but 'does not respond' to his complaint.

In both the sentences, it is not clear whether the event is past or present, since the tenses are not used uniformly. It is better to use two present tense verbs or two past tense verbs, but not one of each in the same sentence.

Thus sentences 1 and 2 can be written as follows:

1. He 'listens' to the presentation and 'gives' his feedback.
2. The manager 'spoke' to the customer but 'did not respond' to his complaint.

Adjectives

Adjectives give information about or describe nouns. Although they play a less important role in a sentence compared to verbs and nouns, they must be used with care. A common tendency is to use strong adjectives, too many adjectives, or superlatives.

The following sentences illustrate the misuse of adjectives:

1. Sales this year have been absolutely 'incredible.'
2. That is the most 'wonderful', 'powerful' and 'moving' speech that I have heard in a long time.
3. Ours is the 'best' product in the market today.

In the first sentence, if a sales report is being written or presented, it would be better to give details about sales figures, rather than describe sales as 'incredible'. In the second sentence, a single adjective could have been used in place of three adjectives, which are too many. The third example is a claim that needs to be defined (i.e., best in what way?), or supported with adequate proof.

Adverbs

In the same way that adjectives describe nouns, adverbs describe or modify verbs, adjectives, or other adverbs. Therefore, the same principles apply when using adverbs – i.e., avoid the use of adverbs that are too strong, or are superlatives. For example, consider the following sentences:

1. Sales have been 'fantastically' high this year.
   The adverb 'fantastically' describes the adjective 'high' and is too strong to be credible.
2. This secretary types the 'fastest'.
   Here, the adverb 'fastest' describes the verb 'types' and is a superlative, which is to be avoided, unless it can be defined or supported with proof.

SELF-ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS – 2

True or False:	
3	The expression "Her voice was silky smooth" is an example of a metaphor. (True/False)
4	It is better to use the word 'interrogate' rather than 'ask'. (True/False)
Fill in the Blanks:	
5	A message will be understood more clearly if _____ nouns are used as subjects in a sentence.

2.3. Active vs. Passive Voice

In the previous sub-section, we studied the correct usage of verbs. Verbs may also be classified as 'active verbs' and 'passive verbs.' Using the 'active voice' means that the subject is the doer of the action, and the subject is active. On the other hand, a sentence in 'passive voice' means that action is done to the Subject or the Subject receives some action. For example, consider the following sentences:

1. John 'wrote' the report. (Active voice)
2. The report 'was written' by John. (Passive voice)

Note that in the first sentence, the use of the active voice draws attention to the doer of the action namely 'John'. This gives a sharper picture to the receiver of the message. In the second sentence, the subject, i.e., the 'report, is emphasised more than the doer of the action, giving a less clear picture to the receiver.

In most cases, the active voice is preferable to the passive since it conveys ideas more vividly. However, there are instances when the use of the passive voice is more appropriate. They are as follows:

- ***When the doer of the action has to be subordinated, rather than highlighted –*** For example, this is the case when writing research reports. It is more important to emphasise what has been done, rather than who has done it. Therefore, it would be better to say "A questionnaire was prepared, and interviews were conducted among a small sample." rather than saying "I prepared a questionnaire and conducted interviews among a small sample" This makes the report more objective, rather than subjective.
- ***When an unpleasant or negative idea has to be subordinated –*** Generally, negative thoughts should be de-emphasised and not highlighted. The passive voice is useful in such cases, as illustrated in the following sentences:
  - The corrections to the report have not been carried out. (Passive voice)
  - You have not carried out the corrections in the report. (Active voice)

The first sentence downplays a negative idea – the fact that the changes in the report have not been included and is therefore less annoying to the receiver than the second. Expressing the same idea in an active voice may seem like pointing fingers at the doer of the action and is likely to upset human relations.

2.4. Spelling and Punctuation

The important point to remember with regard to spelling is the difference between British English and American English. Certain words are spelt differently in British and American English. Table 5.2 illustrates some of these differences.

Table 5.2: Some Differences in Spellings between British and American English

British	**American**
Humour	Humor
Colour	Color
Analyse	Analyze
Organisation	Organization
Programme	Program
Centre	Center
Cheque	Check

Generally, British spellings should be used unless you are addressing an American audience. In any case, either British or American spellings should be uniformly used and not mixed together, in order to ensure greater readability.

Another common mistake made with spelling is confusing the noun form with the verb form. Table 5.3 shows the differences in spellings of the noun and verb forms of some words.

Table 5.3: Differences in Spellings of Noun and Verb Form

Noun	**Verb**
Licence	License
Advice	Advise
Practice	Practise

Some words may sound the same but have different meanings when spelt differently. Some words may include a single vowel that makes them sound different and have very different meanings. It is important not to get confused with the spellings of such words.

For example,

1. ‘Compliment’ means to praise someone, whereas ‘complement’ means to go with (for example, “your jewellery complements your outfit”).

2. 'Stationery' refers to paper, pencils, etc., whereas 'stationary' means 'still or not moving'.

Punctuation

Correct use of punctuation is important in both general writing and business writing. Let us now discuss the main categories of punctuation and their uses.

Apostrophe

Apostrophe is used to form the possessive singular form of words. For example, 'the Company's profits'.

- It is used to form the possessive plural of words ending in 's'. For example, 'the dealers' margin'.
- It is used in expressions that indicate ownership. For example, 'last year's record'.

Parentheses or Brackets

Parentheses or brackets can be used to separate a phrase from the main section of a sentence when it is not related to it grammatically. For example, "The Indian team tried their best (God knows it) but lost in the finals."

Colon

Colon is used to suggest that a list will follow a statement in sentence form. For example," For three reasons, we have decided to expand our market: 1) 2) 3)."

Comma

Comma is used for the following purposes:

- To separate words in a series. For example, "The main punctuation categories are the full stop, the comma, the colon, the semi colon and the apostrophe."
- To separate two adjectives that modifies the same noun. For example, "The MBA exam is a long, difficult and objective type exam."

Dash

Dash is used to separate the words in a sentence that are not necessary for its structure. For example, "His answer – the correct answer – was supported by examples drawn from his own experience"

Full stop or period

Full stop or period is used:

- at the end of a sentence.
- after abbreviations. For example, Dr., No., Jr., etc.

Quotation marks

Quotation marks are used for the following purposes:

- To enclose what is stated by others, verbatim. For example, the manager said, "I will review your progress every month."
- To enclose titles of magazine and newspaper articles. For example, "Progress in Stem Cell Research."

Semicolon

Semicolon is used to express a pause that is longer than that expressed by a comma and is used to separate clauses of a compound sentence when they have a comma.

For example, "We would like the material to be delivered in the morning hours, but before 5 pm will also be convenient." (Without using semicolon)

"We would like the material to be delivered in the morning hours; but if this is not possible for you, before 5 pm will also be convenient." (Using semicolon)

2.5. Common Errors in English

'Indian English' tends to be prone to some common mistakes which should be avoided, in order to make the communication clear and easily understood by the receiver. Some of these mistakes include 'redundancies', 'clichés', and 'frequently misused words.' We will discuss each of these briefly.

Redundancies

Redundancies refer to phrases that contain repetitive or unnecessary words to express the same meaning. This is a common mistake that occurs across the world and must be avoided.

Consider the following sentences:

1. In the first class, the professor taught the 'basic fundamentals' of Marketing.
2. I have to 'return back' home before midnight.

The phrases 'basic fundamentals' and 'return back' are redundancies. In the first sentence, 'basic' is an unnecessary word, since fundamentals themselves are basic; in the second sentence, it is sufficient to say 'return home' and 'back' is an unnecessary word.

A few more examples are:

- True facts
- Past history
- Exactly identical
- Personal opinion

- Another alternative

Redundancy does not serve any purpose and is a mistake since it wastes words.

Clichés

Clichés are phrases that are overused and should be avoided since they make reading monotonous. They should be substituted with more original expressions.

Some commonly used clichés are:

1. 'Last but not least', I would like to thank all the students for attending this session.
2. 'Thanking you in advance', I remain ….
3. Looking forward to meeting and discussing this with you 'at an early date'.
4. 'No problem'.

In the first sentence, 'last but not least', which is a worn expression, could be substituted by 'finally'. The cliché 'thanking you in advance' is presumptuous, since it assumes that the reader will do whatever has been asked. It seems to say that instead of thanking later, you will save time by expressing your thanks now. Therefore, it is better to say 'I shall appreciate your (action)' or 'If you will (action), I shall be grateful.' In the third example, the expression 'at an early date' is too vague and should be substituted with 'soon' or with a specific date. The fourth example 'No problem' is a cliché used commonly by Indians. Although it denies that there is a problem, the problem exists. You might have said for example, that you did not have enough cash to pay for something, in response to which the shopkeeper may have said 'No problem, we accept credit cards'. Therefore, this expression is avoidable.

Frequently misused words

Certain words which sound similar or are spelt slightly different, tend to be used in the wrong context. Some examples are as follows:

1. 'All together' and 'altogether' – 'All together' means 'in one group', whereas 'altogether' means 'completely'.
   For example,
   The answer is 'altogether' wrong.
   The students were 'all together'.
2. 'Already' and 'all ready' – 'Already' means 'at a previous time', whereas 'all ready' means 'everything is ready'.
   For example,

He had ‘already’ left when I called.

The computers are ‘all ready’ to be used.

3. ‘Eminent’ and ‘imminent’ – ‘Eminent’ means ‘well known’, ‘imminent’ means ‘about to happen’.

   For example,

   An ‘eminent’ lawyer will handle the matter. A midterm election is ‘imminent’.

4. ‘Lose’ and ‘loose’ – ‘Lose’ means ‘to fail to keep carefully’, ‘loose’ means ‘not tight’.

   For example,

   Don’t ‘lose’ the money.

   The shirt is too ‘loose’ for him.

5. ‘Principal’ and ‘principle’ – ‘Principal’ means ‘main or primary’, ‘principle’ means ‘rule.’

   For example

   The ‘principal’ reason for leaving early is the peak hour traffic. One of the subjects studied in the first semester of MBA is ‘Principles’ of Management.

SELF-ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS – 3

Match the Following:	
6	Set A A. Semicolon B. Colon C. Quotation marks D. Apostrophe Set B 1. Suggest that a list will follow a statement in sentence form. 2. Used to separate clauses of a compound sentence 3. Used to form the possessive plural of words 4. Used to enclose title of an article
True or False:	
7	Redundancy does not serve any purpose and is a mistake since it wastes words. (True/False)
8	The phrase 'Thanking you in advance’ is an example of redundancy. (True/False)

3. PRINCIPLES OF BUSINESS WRITING

Having dealt with writing in general, we will now discuss the specifics of business writing. As pointed out earlier, the language, style, and tone of business writing are very different from general writing. Therefore, we will examine these aspects in detail.

3.1. Tone

We discussed the tone of voice or 'paralanguage', in an earlier Unit. We learned that the spoken words, however perfect, can convey a negative message if the tone of voice is not consistent with what is said. Tone is equally important in conveying written messages, particularly business-related messages.

In written communication, tone refers to the way a statement sounds, which in turn, depends on the choice of words. A sentence or statement may be grammatically perfect but may convey a negative message if the choice of words is wrong.

For example, "You failed to meet the sales target".

This statement has a negative tone since it emphasizes what could not be achieved. The same idea could be expressed in a more positive tone, by emphasising what could have been done instead.

For example, "With a little extra effort, you could have achieved the target".

This example shows that even a negative idea can be expressed in positive language through the use of appropriate words.

The tone of business communication should also be confident. You should avoid language that makes you sound unsure of yourself.

For example, "I hope you will agree that my qualifications match your job profile".

Beginning the sentence with 'I hope' creates the impression that you lack confidence in yourself. It might be better to say "On reviewing my bio-data, you will find that my qualifications match your job needs in the following respects…"

While it is important to be self-assured, avoid sounding overconfident and pompous.

For example, "I am sure you will agree that our Company has the best reputation for quality and service".

Instead, you can write the same as "We shall try to live up to our reputation for quality and service."

Another aspect of tone is to sound courteous and sincere. This builds goodwill and good relations and increases the likelihood of a message achieving its objectives. Avoid statements such as the following:

You sent your complaint to the wrong department. You should have sent it to the shipping department.

This sounds very discourteous and rude when responding to a customer complaint. Instead, it might be better to say "We have sent your complaint to the concerned department, which will be contacting you shortly."

Sincerity also means avoiding exaggeration and flattery, especially when communicating with customers. Consider the following examples:

1. We are more interested in your satisfaction than in making profits.
2. You are such a valued customer that we shall go to any lengths to earn your satisfaction.

The first sentence sounds insincere since the main objective of any organisation is to make profits. The second sentence is exaggerated and unduly flatters the customer. It should be toned down by saying something such as "We value your goodwill and will make quick efforts to ensure your satisfaction."

Finally, the tone of business writing should be non-discriminatory. This means the chosen language must not be offensive to gender, religion, or race.

One way of ensuring this is to avoid 'sexist language' by using neutral job titles, or titles that do not imply that a job is held only by a man.

For example,

'Chairperson', instead of 'Chairman.' 'Salesperson', instead of 'Salesman.'

If the reader's gender is not known, use a non-sexist salutation such as 'Dear Customer, Investor, or Advertiser', instead of 'Dear Sir or Madam.'

Personal titles and salutations such as 'Dr.', 'Professor', etc., should be used wherever appropriate.

3.2. Emphasis and Subordination

A business writer can be compared to an artist or a musician. Just like an artist or a musician, a business writer too tries to make certain elements stand out and others get little attention. An important principle of business writing is to emphasise important ideas and downplay unimportant ideas, so as to make the reader understand what you consider to be significant. Generally, pleasant

and important thoughts are emphasised, while unpleasant and insignificant thoughts are subordinated or de-emphasised.

The techniques that a business writer can use for emphasis are:

- Place the idea in the first paragraph or in the last paragraph, in order to get attention.
- Put the word that you wish to emphasise first or last in the sentence.

For example, 'Success' comes through sincere efforts. 'Failure' will result without them.

Or, the event was a 'success'. Without your efforts, it would have been a 'failure'.

- Use the active voice to emphasise the doer of the action and the passive voice to emphasise the receiver of the action.

For example, 'John' made the presentation. (Active) 'The presentation' was made by John. (Passive)

- Use words such as 'primary', 'major' and 'significant' to lay emphasis. For example, "Cost is a 'significant' factor to be taken into consideration."
- Use repetition.

For example, "The Tata Nano is an 'inexpensive' car. It is 'inexpensive' to purchase and 'inexpensive' to maintain."

- Number the ideas, so as to rank them in order of importance.

For example, the main reasons for his poor performance are – 1) Lack of training 2) Lack of team skills and 3) Lack of motivation.

- Use visual elements such as bold type, capital letters, bigger font size and underlined words to emphasise key ideas.

For example, "The Reva electric car is '25% LESS POLLUTING' than other cars".

- Use compares and contrast to convey the similarities and differences.

For example, "Although oranges and apples grow in trees, oranges are citric fruits".

- Use parallelism, where a noun is listed with other nouns, an -ing form with other -ing forms, etc.

For example,

Sentence 1: Tom plays the piano.

Sentence 2: Tom plays the violin.

Parallelism: Tom plays the piano and the violin.

Another point to be remembered regarding emphasis in business writing is to stress what is known as the 'you attitude', rather than the 'me attitude.' This means explaining the benefits to the reader, understanding his situation and answering his unspoken question 'How is it relevant to me?'

For example, instead of saying, 'Our bank will be open 24 hours', say 'You will be able to avail round-the-clock banking service.

3.3. Write at an Appropriate Level of Readability

The third important rule of business writing is to tailor your writing to your audience and to make it simple enough for even a layperson to read and understand.

As pointed out in an earlier section, readability is determined by the length of words and sentences. Robert Gunning developed what is known as the 'Fog Index' or a readability formula to measure the readability of a piece of writing. According to this formula, the appropriate reading level in business writing should be between 8 and 11.

Calculation of the Fog Index involves the following steps:

1. Select a written passage of approximately 100 words.
2. Calculate the average length of a sentence by dividing the total number of words in the passage by the number of sentences.
3. Find the number of difficult words. A word may be defined as difficult if it contains three or more syllables (example, 'communication'). Determine the number of difficult words per hundred, by dividing the total number of words in the passage into the number of difficult words, then by multiplying this figure by 100.
4. Add the number of difficult words per hundred and the average sentence length.
5. Multiply the figure obtained in step 4 by 0.4, to calculate the reading grade level for which the passage was written, or the Fog Index.

Ideally, the Fog Index should be between 8 and 11 for most business writing, indicating that a reader between the eighth grade and the eleventh grade should be able to understand it without difficulty.

Common parallelism mistakes made:

1. We often forget to complete the second construction.

For example, "Sheela likes to run and swim". The correct sentence is "Sheela likes to run and to swim".

2. We do not maintain consistency in the pronouns and verbs used.

For example, “Raju wanted a cookie, but the last one was eaten by Ram”. The correct sentence is “Raju wanted a cookie, but Ram ate the last one”.

Activity - 1

Select an article from any business publication and measure its readability by calculating the Fog Index. Is the level of readability appropriate for the audience?

(Refer sub-section 5.3.3 for detailed guidelines)

SELF-ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS – 4

Fill in the Blanks:	
6	Using the passive voice is a technique of _____.
7	Readability is determined by _____ & _____.
True or False:	
8	According to the 'Fog Index' formula, the appropriate reading level in business writing should be between eight and eleven. (True/False)

4. SUMMARY

Let us recapitulate the important concepts discussed in this unit:

- The three stages of writing methodology, prewriting, writing and review must be followed to make written communication more effective.
- It is a good practice to choose proper words to make the writing more effective.
- You have to avoid the use of complicated words, jargon, slang and colourful language while writing.
- You must be very careful while using the parts of speech - nouns, pronouns, adjectives, verbs, adjectives and adverbs as incorrect usage can lead to misunderstanding.
- Proper and correct use of active voice, passive voice, spelling and punctuation help to minimise the ambiguity and confusion during written communication. They also increase the effectiveness in communication.
- The right use of tone, emphasis and subordination adds value to communication and increases clarity.
- Tailor your writing to ensure that you communicate with your audience using minimum, simple and effective words.

5. GLOSSARY

Concise	-	Expressing much in a few words or brief and compacted.
Courteous	-	Exhibiting courtesy and politeness.
Parallelism	-	Similarity of construction or meaning of clauses placed side by side.
Phrase	-	Two or more words in sequence that form a syntactic unit that is less than a complete sentence.
Presumptuous	-	Going beyond what is right or proper.

6. TERMINAL QUESTIONS

1. Explain briefly the four steps of the review process.
2. Select any piece of general writing from a newspaper or magazine, of approximately 250 words in length. Evaluate it by determining the number of simple and complicated words, the correct usage of parts of speech and the use of jargon, slang and metaphors. Is it well or badly written, in your opinion?
3. What are some of the consequences of spelling and punctuation errors, redundancies, clichés and misuse of words?
4. How does general writing differ from business writing, in terms of language, style and tone?

7. ANSWERS

7.1. Self-Assessment Questions

1. Prewriting
2. False. You check for wordiness, long sentences, complex and incomplete sentences when you review for micro issues.
3. True
4. False. As it is better to rely on plain and simple words, it is better to use the word 'ask' rather than 'interrogate'.
5. Concrete
6. A - 2, B - 1, C -4, D - 3
7. True
8. False. The phrase 'Thanking you in advance' is an example for clichés.
9. Subordination/de-emphasis
10. Sentence length/word length
11. True

7.2. Terminal Questions Answers

1. The four steps of the review process are: review for strategy, review for macro issues, review for micro issues and review for correctness. Refer section 2.1 for details.
2. Writing style can be vastly improved through the choice of words. Some of the common problems of word choice include the use of complicated words, use of jargon, slang and colourful language and mistakes in various parts-of-speech categories. Refer Section 2.2 for details.
3. The important point to be remembered with regard to spelling is the difference between British English and American English. Some words are spelt differently in British and American English. Refer section 2.4 for details
4. Business writing must focus on important ideas and downplay unimportant ideas, to make the reader understand what you consider to be significant. Refer section 3 for more details.

8. CASE STUDY

FOCs Written Communication Programme

The Foreign and Commonwealth Office (FCO) initiated a programme, Professional Skills for Government (PSG) to develop professional skills for its civil service employees. This aimed to motivate the employees and foster long term goals of improvement by imparting skill in the employees to carry out their work effectively.

Objectives of the Programme

FCO identified effective written communication as the most important skill that all employees had to master depending on their grade and responsibilities. The main objectives of the communication skill enhancement programme were to:

- Review and adopt key principles of effective writing.
- Add value to the written communication skills of each employee.
- Minimise the time spent on redrafting documents.

Challenges

Some of the most important challenges to achieve the objectives were:

- To gain the interest and attention of the employees at all levels.
- To ensure that all the current guidelines of FCO for drafting and writing are incorporated into the programme.
- To adopt follow-on coaching sessions to each employee's personal objectives.

Solutions

To meet the objectives and overcome the challenges, the following strategies were adopted in the training programmes:

- Two programmes 'Effective Writing' and 'Writing with Impact' were planned and carried out. These programmes were developed considering employees at different levels.
- In order to develop specific skills, two follow-up individual coaching sessions are offered to each employee. The employees work closely with the trainer and they use authentic business documents to ensure that the required skill are targeted appropriately during the training.

Result

The employees showed great interest and regularly attended the programme. Employees' confidence and accuracy in written communication increased. This decreased repeated redrafting of documents and improved efficiency.

Discussion Questions:

1. What are the written communication programme objectives of FCO? (Hint: Refer to section 'Objectives of the Programme' in the Case Study)
2. How did FCO's written communication programme overcome the challenges to meet the objectives? (Hint: Refer to section 'Solution' in the Case Study)

(Source: http://www.communicaid.com/pdf/casestudies/Communication%20Skills%20-%20FCO%20Case%20Study.pdf)

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